ROSTAS APP

COORDINATORS GUIDE

Knox Church Waitara • April 2026

A complete guide to building rosters, managing replacements, and protecting your volunteers' energy.

Introduction

Rostas is the coordinator app for managing Knox Church Waitara's volunteer rosters. It builds rosters for Sunday services, Music team, and Nourish (fortnightly), connects to Infoodle for volunteer data, and handles notifications, reminders, and SMS replacements automatically.

This guide covers everything you need: from collecting availability through to handling replacements. Part B covers Roster Coordinator tasks. Part C covers additional Overall Coordinator tasks (Lisa & Sharon).

Who Can Do What

Task	Roster Coordinator	Overall Coordinator	Technical Owner (Guy)
Send availability emails	✓	✓	✓
Role preference setup	✓	✓	✓
Volunteer frequency settings	✓	✓	✓
Build, preview & send roster	✓	✓	✓
Season editing	✓	✓	✓
Manual volunteer replacement	✓	✓	✓
Volunteer sync from Infoodle	—	✓	✓
Config & settings	—	✓	✓
Adding volunteers (via Infoodle)	—	✓	✓
Adding a new roster type	—	✓	✓
Apps Script / technical changes	—	—	✓

> Part B of this guide covers all tasks marked ✓ for Roster Coordinators. Part C covers the additional tasks available to Overall Coordinators only.

PART B — ROSTER COORDINATOR

Sunday Coordinator · Music Coordinator · Nourish Coordinator

1. Getting Started with Rostas

Rostas is built primarily for desktop access, though it can also be used on a tablet or mobile phone. Your coordinator will send you a link or invite when you are set up.

The Rostas Views

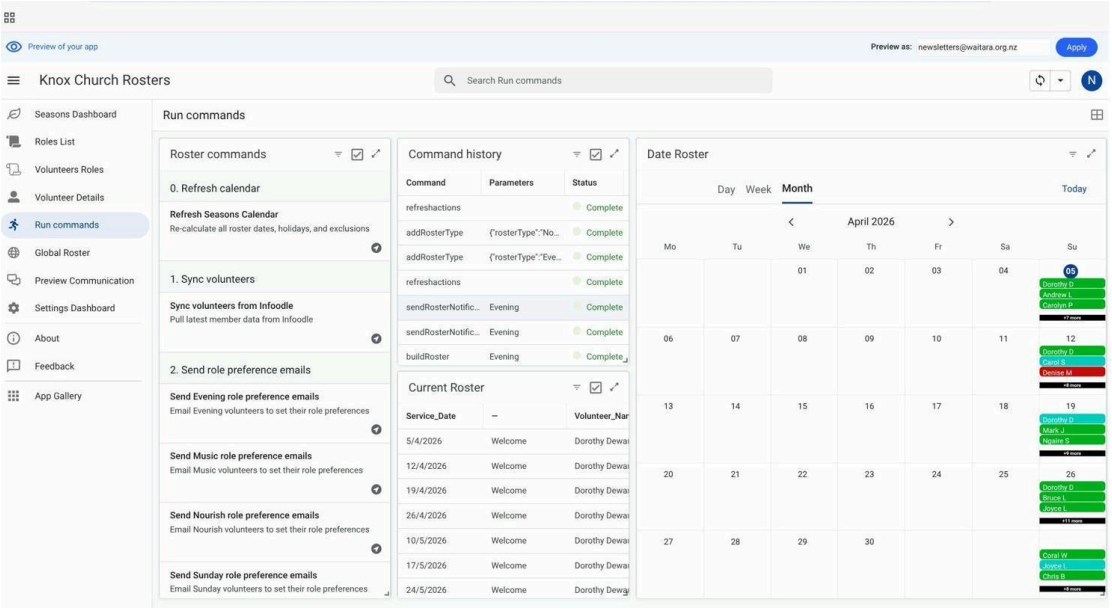
When you open Rostas you will see these views in the left-hand sidebar. Tap the relevant view to navigate to that area of the system:

> **The Run Commands view is your main working area.**
>
> This is where you trigger all roster actions — sending emails, building the roster, and sending notifications. Each button runs a single action and shows you the result when it is done.
>
> After tapping a button, Rostas queues the action and runs it within a minute. A Complete message appears in the Result column when done — always check this before moving on.

Reading Results

Every action writes a result message in the Command history panel. Common results:

- Filled: 12, Pending: 3, Unfilled: 0 — roster built successfully. Pending means a volunteer marked Unsure but has been provisionally assigned.
- Unfilled: 2 — two slots could not be filled. Review the roster and handle manually.
- Sent to: 14 volunteers — notification emails dispatched.
- Error: … — something went wrong. Note the message and contact tech support if it repeats.



Run Commands — your main working area. Each button triggers one roster action.

2. The Roster Cycle

Each roster follows the same sequence of steps. Run them in order — skipping a step or running them out of order can produce unexpected results.

Step	Action	What it does	Who
0	**Refresh calendar**	Recalculates season dates, overlays NZ public and school holidays.	Roster Coordinator
1	**Sync volunteers**	Pulls latest volunteer data from Infoodle (auto 2am or manual).	Overall Coordinator
2	**Role preferences**	Send role picker emails so volunteers set their roles — or set them yourself.	Roster Coordinator
3	**Send availability emails**	Ask volunteers which dates they are available for.	Roster Coordinator
3b	**Check frequency settings**	Set a monthly cap per roster type per volunteer.	Roster Coordinator
4	**Build roster**	System assigns volunteers to roles based on availability & preferences.	Roster Coordinator
6	**Preview communications**	Check email template formatting, names, dates before sending.	Roster Coordinator

5	**Send notifications**	Volunteers receive assignment email and SMS.	Roster Coordinator

⏰ **Timing tip:**

Send availability emails at least 2–3 weeks before the first date of the new season. Allow volunteers 5–7 days to respond before building the roster.

3. Step 0 — Refresh the Seasons Calendar

Seasons Dashboard

Run this at the start of each roster build and any time you make changes to season dates. It recalculates all roster dates, overlays NZ public holidays and school holidays, and updates the calendar view.

Run commands

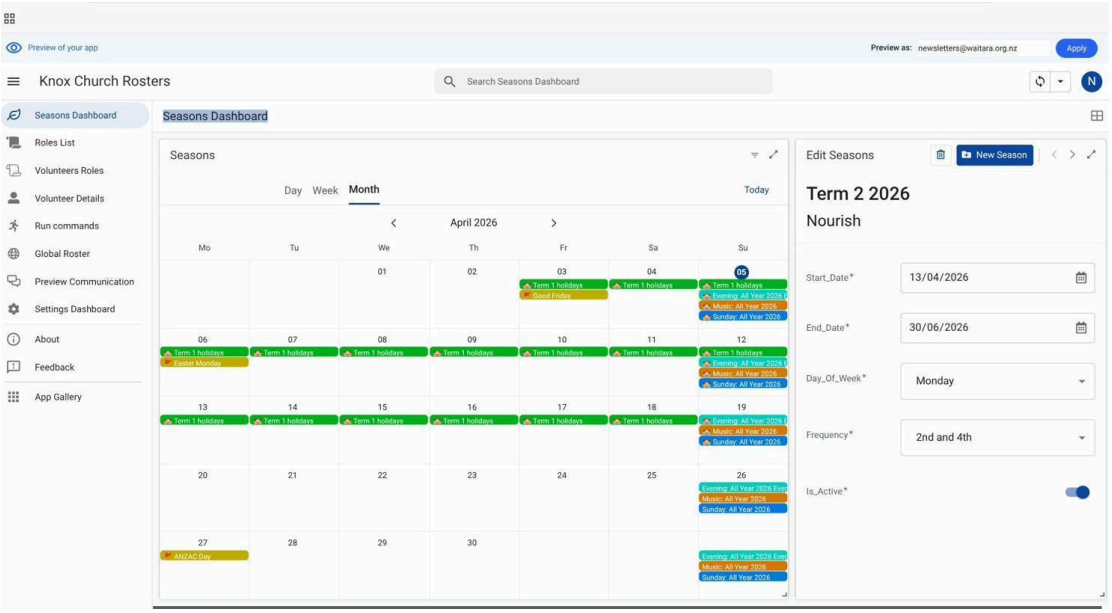
Step 0 Refresh calendar

In Rostas → Run Commands, tap 0. Refresh calendar.

Wait for the result message to confirm completion.

Check the Seasons Calendar view to confirm dates look correct.

⚠️ Always run Step 0 after editing season start/end dates, adding a new season, or at the beginning of a new roster cycle.



Seasons Dashboard — calendar view with season dates and public holidays overlaid.

4. Step 2 — Role Preferences

Role preferences tell the system which roles each volunteer is willing to do. The system needs this information before it can build the roster.

Option A — Volunteers Set Their Own Preferences

Volunteers receive a personalised link and tap through each role, choosing 'Yes I do this', 'Happy to fill in', or 'Not for me'.

Step 2 Send role preference emails

In Rostas → Run Commands, tap 2. Send role preference emails.

Volunteers receive an email with a personalised link.

Allow a few days for responses before building the roster.

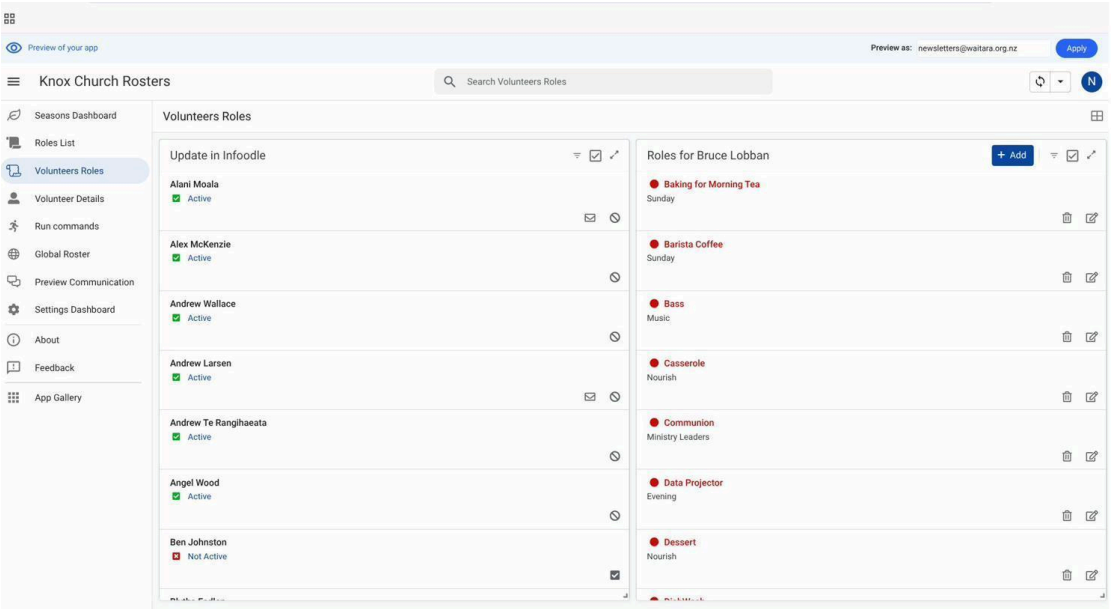
Check who has responded in the Volunteers Roles view.

Option B — You Set Preferences on Their Behalf

If a volunteer is not comfortable using the link, or for new volunteers who have not yet set preferences, you can set their roles directly in Rostas.

Volunteers Roles

Open the Volunteers Roles view. Select the volunteer on the left, then review and edit their role assignments on the right.



Volunteers Roles view — select a volunteer on the left to see and edit their role assignments.

Roles List

> 💡 **When to use each option:**
>
> The Roles List view shows all active roles and their settings. The Volunteers Roles view shows per-volunteer assignments. Send the email link at the start of a new season; set preferences directly in Rostas for day-to-day adjustments or less tech-confident volunteers.

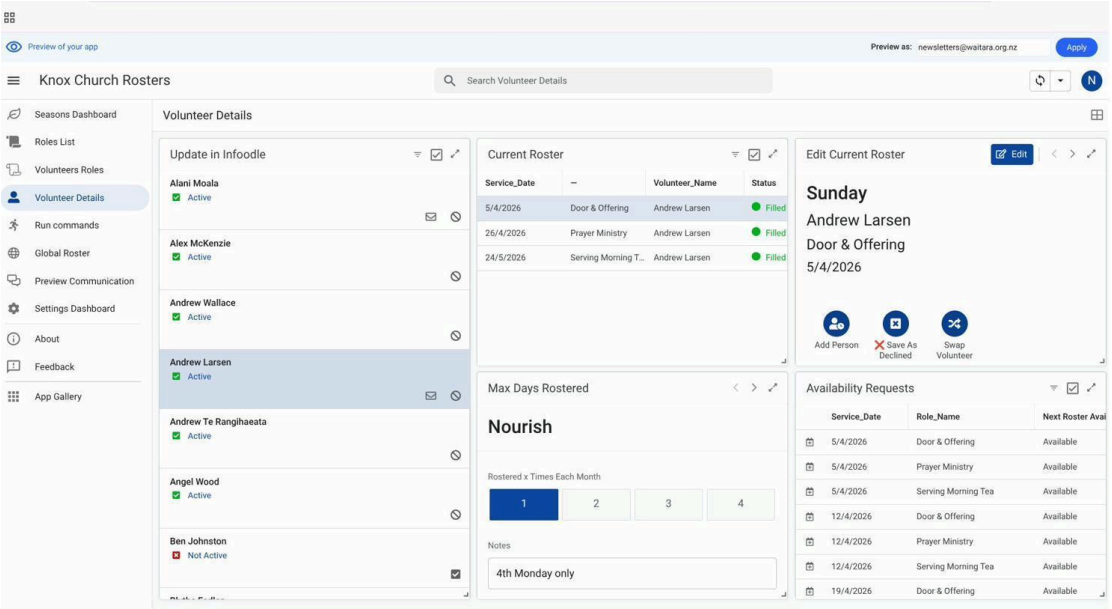
5. Volunteer Frequency Settings

Individual Details

Frequency settings control how many times per month a volunteer can be rostered for a given roster type. The roster engine strictly enforces these caps.

To set or update frequency:

- In Rostas, go to the Individual Details view. Select the volunteer from the left panel.
- Use the arrow buttons (‹ ›) to switch between roster types if the volunteer serves in more than one.
- In the Max Days Rostered panel (bottom centre), tap 1, 2, 3, or 4 to set the monthly maximum. The default is 4 for weekly rosters, 2 for fortnightly rosters.
- Add a note if helpful (e.g. '4th Monday only' or 'family commitments').
- Save. The change takes effect at the next roster build.



Individual Details view — Current Roster (centre), Max Days Rostered (bottom centre), and Availability Requests (right).

> ⚠️ **Frequency caps are enforced automatically at roster build time.**
>
> A volunteer who has already reached their monthly cap will not be assigned to any further dates in that month, even if they are marked Available.

6. Step 3 — Send Availability Emails

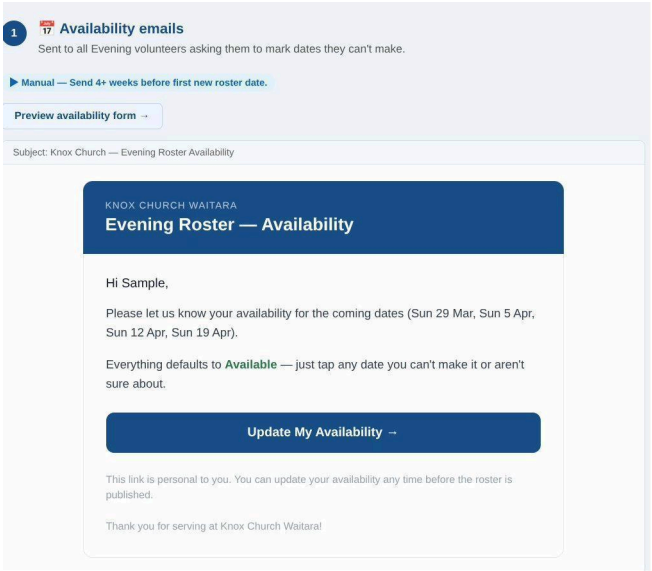
Availability emails go to all active volunteers for your roster type. Each volunteer receives a personalised link showing the upcoming dates. They tap each date to mark themselves Available, Unsure, or Can't make it, then tap Save.

Step 3 Send availability emails

In Rostas → Run Commands, tap 3. Send availability emails.

The result confirms how many emails were sent.

Allow 5–7 days for volunteers to respond. Volunteers who do not respond are treated as Unavailable at roster build time.



The availability email volunteers receive — a personalised link takes them straight to the form.

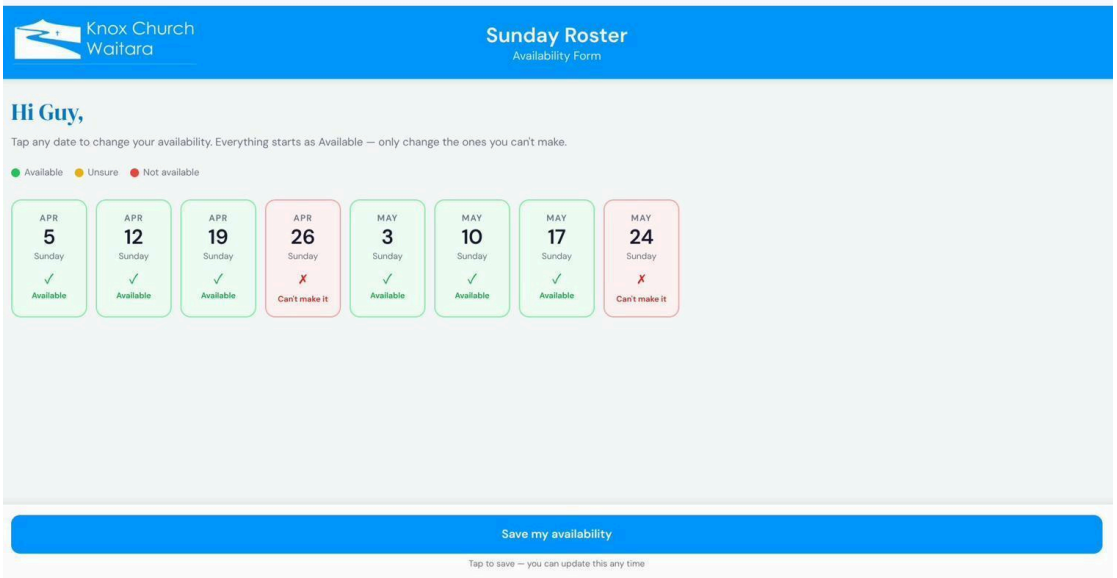
The Three Availability States

✅ **Available —** The default starting state for all dates.

❓ **Unsure —** Signals caution. The volunteer may be provisionally assigned.

❌ **Can't make it —** Immediately removes them from the scheduling pool for that date.

Everything starts as Available — volunteers only spend time changing the dates they cannot make.



The availability form — volunteers tap each date to cycle through Available, Unsure, and Can't make it.

What if someone missed the email?

You can update a volunteer's availability directly in Rostas via the Individual Details view. Select the volunteer from the left panel, then use the Availability Requests panel (bottom right) to find the date and update their status.

7. Step 4 — Build the Roster

The roster engine assigns volunteers to roles based on their availability and role preferences. It works through four priority tiers and within each tier selects the volunteer who has been rostered least recently.

The Four Priority Tiers

Tier	Availability	Role Match	Sort within tier
1	✅ Available	Primary role (Yes, I do this)	Fewest assignments in lookback window, then longest since this specific role
2	✅ Available	Fillable role (Happy to fill in)	Same as Tier 1
3	❓ Unsure	Primary role	Same as Tier 1
4	❓ Unsure	Fillable role	Same as Tier 1

Run commands

Step 4 Build roster

In Rostas → Run Commands, tap 4. Build roster.

The Music roster can take up to 10 minutes — this is normal.

The system builds the next 8 weeks of dates by default (configurable per roster type in Settings — ROSTER_BUILD_WEEKS_{Type}).

Check the result message: Filled, Pending, and Unfilled counts.

Review the roster in the Global Roster view before sending.

Reviewing the Result — The Traffic Light System

🟢 Filled	🟡 Pending	🔴 Unfilled
Volunteer confirmed and ready. No action needed.	Provisionally assigned (volunteer marked Unsure). Monitor.	No suitable volunteer was found. Attempt to fill before sending.

⚠️ **Do not send notifications until you have reviewed the roster.**

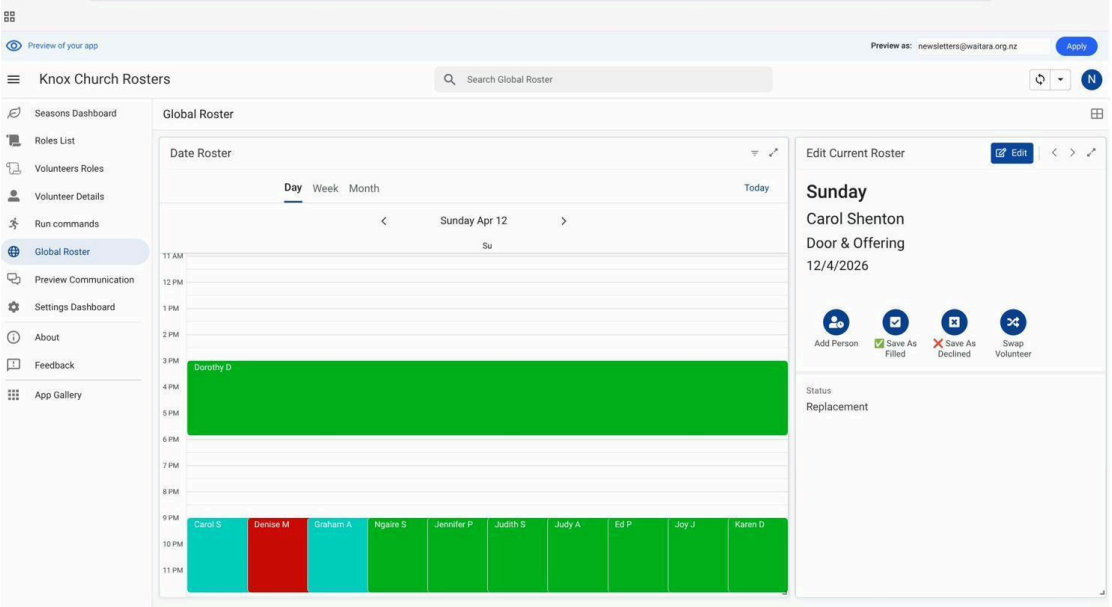
Check for Unfilled slots and any obvious problems first. Once notifications are sent, volunteers receive their assignments immediately.

Editing the Roster Before Sending

Global Roster

In the Global Roster view, tap or click any assignment to open the edit panel on the right. You will see three options:

- Replace Volunteer — a dropdown offers a list of suitable replacement volunteers.
- Save as Filled — manually confirm a Pending (Unsure) assignment.
- Save as Declined — this automatically starts the SMS replacement chain to find a substitute.



Global Roster Day view — tap any assignment to open the edit panel. Use Save as Declined to start the automated SMS replacement chain.

8. Step 6 — Preview Communications

Communications

Before sending notifications, use the Preview button to see exactly what the notification email and SMS will look like. This is the same view volunteers will see.

Run commands

Step 6 Preview communications

In Rostas → Run Commands, tap 6. Preview communications.

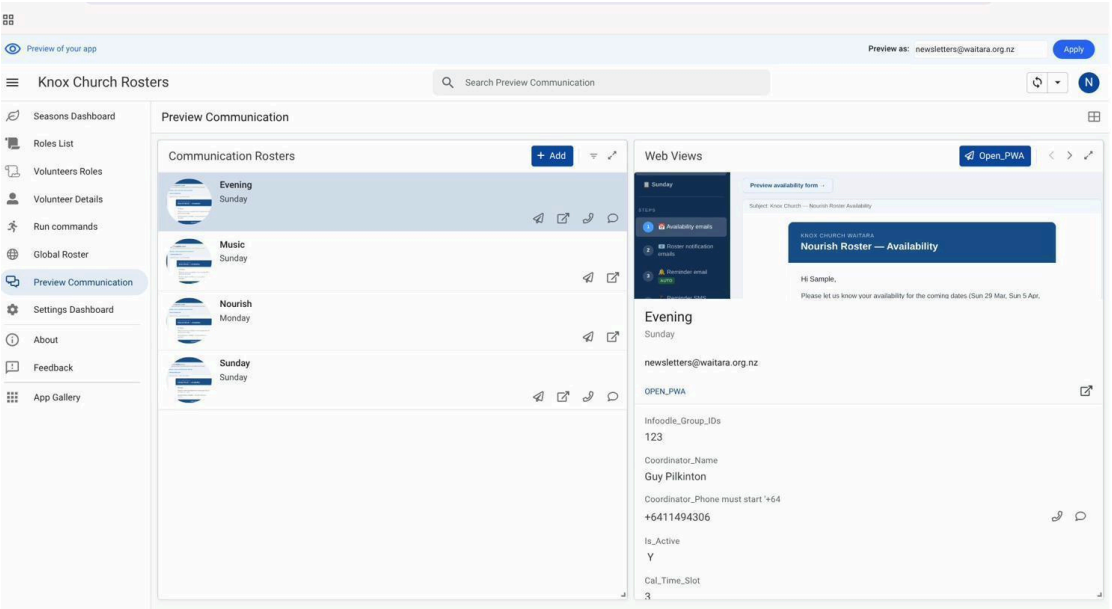
A browser page opens showing the notification email template.

Check volunteer names, roles, dates, and links all look correct.

You can also adjust the wording of SMS messages here.

Close the preview and proceed to Step 5 when satisfied.

💡 Keep any wording changes generic and appropriate for all roster types, or revert changes afterwards so the next coordinator does not encounter problems.



Preview Communication view — tap Open PWA to see the full email template. Check names, roles, dates, and the Can't make it button.

9. Step 5 — Send Notifications

Notifications go to every volunteer with a Filled or Pending assignment. Each volunteer receives an email with their role and date, and a link to confirm (for pending)or decline. An SMS is also sent.

Step 5 Send notifications

In Rostas → Run Commands, tap 5. Send notifications.

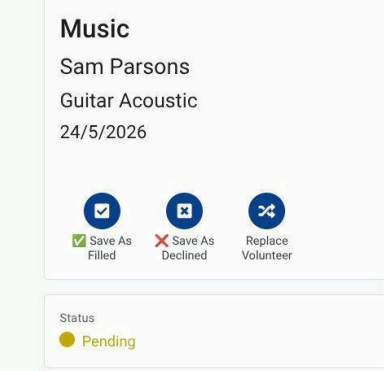
The result confirms how many volunteers were notified.

Volunteers receive their email and SMS within a few minutes.

📬 **What volunteers receive:**

Each volunteer gets an email showing their name, role, and dates rostered. The email includes a Can't make it link. If they tap it, the SMS replacement chain runs automatically — coordinators do not need to do anything when this happens.

There is also a link to a simplified printable roster. For Pending (Unsure) assignments, volunteers are shown Yes, I can make it and Can't make it buttons so they can confirm or decline.



The assignment edit panel — Save As Filled confirms a Pending assignment; Save As Declined starts the automated SMS replacement chain.

10. Manual Replacement

Use manual replacement when a volunteer contacts you directly — for example, they phone to say they cannot make it and suggest someone else, or you need to make a swap yourself without waiting for the SMS chain.

Step — Manual replace

Go to Rostas → Global Roster or Individual Details view.

Select the assignment you want to change.

Tap Swap Volunteer, then select the replacement from the dropdown.

Save. The system processes the swap within 1 minute.

Check the Status column — it changes from Pending to Done when complete.

📬 **The replacement volunteer get's an automatic notification after a manual swap with the usual links to "I can't make it" button, "roster view", "view roster online, and print roster".**

11. The SMS Replacement Chain

When a volunteer taps 'Can't make it' in their notification email, the system automatically begins contacting other available volunteers by SMS. You do not need to do anything.

What happens automatically:

- The system finds the next suitable available volunteer for that role and date.
- It sends them an SMS with a link to accept or decline.
- If they accept → they are added to the roster and the chain stops.
- If they decline or do not respond within 2 hours (standard) or 15 minutes (urgent/imminent events) → the next volunteer is contacted.
- If no one accepts → the coordinator receives an email letting you know the slot is still unfilled.

> 🌙 **Quiet Hours:**
>
> SMS messages are not sent between 9:00 PM and 7:00 AM NZ time. If the chain is running overnight, it pauses and resumes in the morning. Quiet hours can be adjusted in Settings — search for 'Quiet'.

12. Checking the Status Dashboard

The Status Dashboard shows the status of all notifications sent from Rostas — emails, SMS reminders, and replacement requests. Check it after running any notification step to confirm delivery. If an error appears, use the Email Tech Support button to send an error report to Guy automatically.

Note: the full Audit Log (which records every system event including roster builds and sync operations) is accessible to the Technical Support only. If something does not look right, contact Tech Support and quote the error message.

Common things to look for:

- SMS FAILED — a text message did not deliver. Usually a Twilio issue. Note the error and contact Tech Support if it persists.
- Chain exhausted — no volunteer accepted the replacement. The slot is still unfilled.
- Assignment not found — a Manual Replace request used an incorrect assignment. Check and resubmit.

> ⚠️ **If you see repeated errors, do not keep retrying.**
>
> Note what you were doing and the error message, and contact tech support. Retrying a failed action can sometimes create duplicate assignments.

PART C — OVERALL COORDINATOR Tasks

All rosters · Volunteer management · System settings

13. Step 1 — Volunteer Sync from Infoodle

Infoodle is the church's main membership database. Rostas syncs volunteer data from Infoodle every morning at 2am automatically. You can also run a manual sync at any time.

Run a manual sync when:

- A new volunteer has been added to Infoodle and needs to appear in Rostas immediately.
- A volunteer's contact details (email or mobile) have changed in Infoodle.
- You are about to build a roster and want to make sure you have the latest data.

Run commands

Step 1 Sync volunteers from Infoodle

In Rostas → Run Commands, tap 1. Sync volunteers from Infoodle.

The sync runs in two steps and takes about 1–2 minutes.

The result confirms how many volunteers were updated.

Check the Volunteers view to confirm new or updated records appear.

⚠️ **Important:**

Volunteer name changes and Group/Roster membership are made in Infoodle, not in Rostas. Any changes made directly to the Volunteers tab in the spreadsheet will be overwritten by the next sync. Always update volunteer details in Infoodle first, then run a sync.

Adding a New Volunteer

New volunteers must be added to Infoodle first and assigned to the correct Infoodle group for their roster type. Once in Infoodle, run a manual sync and they will appear in Rostas. You will then need to set their role preferences before they can be included in a roster build.

14. Settings and Configuration

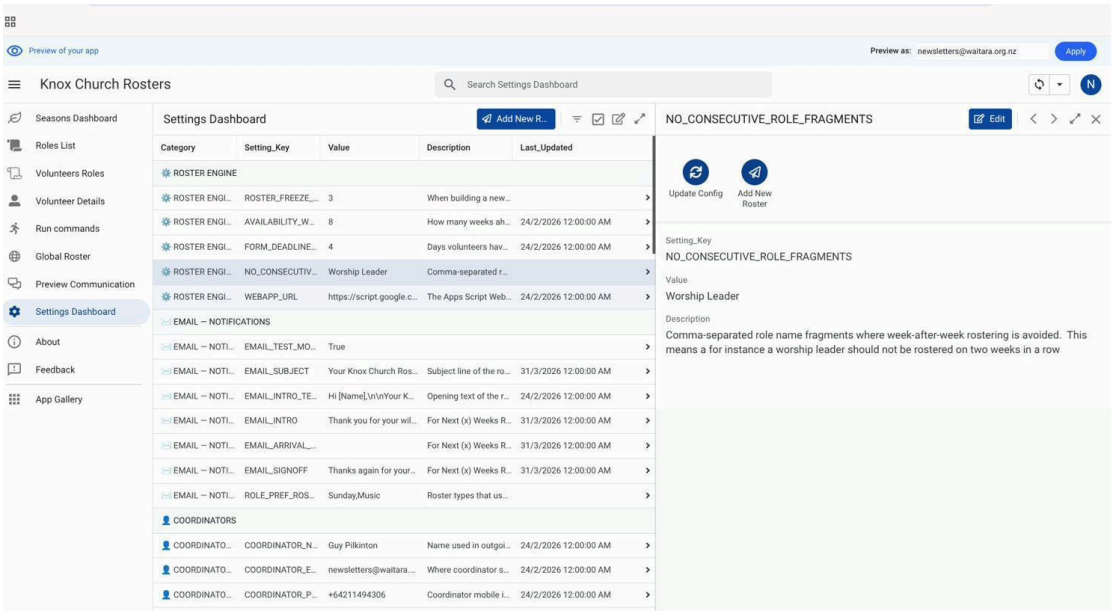
Settings Dashboard

System settings control how Rostas behaves — coordinator email addresses, reminder timing, and which features are active. Managed through the Settings Dashboard view in Rostas.

✅ Safe to Change	🔒 Leave to Tech Support
• Coordinator name and email for each roster type • Coordinator mobile number (for SMS test mode) • Reminder timing — minutes between SMS replacement messages • Email and SMS message wording templates	• SMS_ENABLED and SMS_TEST_MODE — control live SMS delivery. Contact Guy before changing. • WEBAPP_URL — volunteer web app address. Only changes on redeployment. • INFOODLE_GROUP_MAP and Infoodle credentials — technical settings for sync. • ROSTER_FREEZE_WEEKS — controls which dates are protected from rebuild.

⚠️ **If you are not sure whether a setting is safe to change, contact Guy first.**

Some settings affect the whole system across all roster types. An incorrect value can prevent roster builds or stop emails and SMS from sending.



Settings Dashboard — settings are grouped by category. Tap a row to view details and use Edit to change a value. Use Add New Roster to add a new roster type.

15. When to Contact Tech Support

Most day-to-day operations are fully self-contained in Rostas. The situations below require more technical involvement:

- The volunteer web app URL has changed and needs updating (after a system redeployment).
- Repeated errors appear in the Status Dashboard that do not resolve on their own.
- SMS messages stop delivering to volunteers.
- The system triggers need to be reinstalled (e.g. after a technical issue).
- Any change to Infoodle connection settings or API credentials.
- Anything that requires opening the Apps Script editor.

📞 **Contact**

newsletters@waitara.org.nz

When contacting Tech support about an error, include the error message from the Status Dashboard and a description of what you were doing when it occurred.